10. Three Sacks of Rice

You may have read many stories about three brothers. Usually, two of them – the elder ones are strong, clever but unkind. They laugh at the youngest one because he is too simple and soft-hearted.

Our story also has three brothers who lived in a small town but they were all three of them honest, kind and hard-working. The elder one ran a shop, the middle one was a priest and the youngest one had just finished his education. He had started taking up odd jobs to earn some money and to learn a trade. All three of them were fond of their mother. She had worked hard to bring up the three of them after the sudden death of their father.

One day, their father's friend visited the mother. He said, "Sister, you know that I have a very prosperous business.

But now I am getting old, and my only daughter is of a marriageable age. I am looking for a son-in-law who would be a good husband to my daughter and who would also handle my business well. I like all your sons. If you permit, I'll marry my daughter to one of them but before that I have a plan."

He discussed the plan with her and she agreed quite readily.

The next day, the friend went to each of the three brothers one by one. He gave them each a sack of rice and said, "My dear boy, I am going away for a few months for some necessary work. Please look after this sack of rice till I come back."

The friend went away. Many months passed but he did not return. It was nearly a year before he came back. He visited the eldest brother first. The eldest brother welcomed him and gave him a small purse full of money. "Uncle, you had left a sack of rice with me. After a few months, I was worried that it may get spoilt. Therefore I sold the rice to my customers. Here's the money I got. Please accept it."

"Thank you, my boy, you are such an honest person !"

Then the friend went to see the middle brother, who was a priest. The priest greeted him with joy and affection. He said, "Uncle, remember you had left a sack of rice with me, an year ago ? I had kept it for many months, but then I was worried that it may get spoilt. I distributed the rice among the poor in your name. They all blessed you for satisfying their hunger. However, I did that without your permission and I am willing to pay you back for the rice."

"No, my boy, you acted wisely and kindly. The blessings that I got from the poor people are enough for me. Please don't even think about the money any more."

When the friend went to visit the youngest son, he, too, welcomed him with love and respect. But he said that he had a confession to make. "The sack of rice was lying with me for a long time. But then I had an idea. I often go to a neighbouring farm to help with the work. I borrowed an unused plot of land from the farmer. I exchanged the sack of rice for paddy and sowed the paddy in the plot. Fortunately, the crop grew well and yielded twenty-five sacks of rice. I have kept back five of the sacks and sold twenty of them. Here's the money. If you allow, I would like to keep a part of it as my share considering the labour and money I spent to get it all done."

A wide smile spread on the friend's face. He had found his future son-in-law.

Things to do :

1. Find the opposites of the following words from the lesson.

* begun * bought * reject * eldest * lent * earned * narrow

2. Answer the following questions.

(1) What common qualities did the three brothers have ?

(2) What was the businessman looking for ? Why ?

(3) How did the middle brother use the rice ?

(4) Was it right for the youngest brother to ask for a share in the money ? Why ?

3. Language Study (See pages 84-88.)

(1) Read the highlighted words.

* All three of them were honest, kind and hardworking.
* You are such an honest person.

The highlighted words are adjectives.
Now find at least five other adjectives from the lesson.

(2) List as many words as you can that will go with the given **adjective**.
(At least 3 each.)

Example : sudden – sudden change, sudden shower, sudden fall

* simple * odd * only * honest * long

4. Activities

(1) Imagine you are one of the three brothers.
Write in short what you did with the rice.

(2) Find any other story of three brothers or three sisters
and rewrite it in your own words.

(3) Find out how rice is cultivated. Describe the process with the help of
pictures or diagrams.

5. Group Work

Form a group of 4 or 5. Make a 'storyboard' for the story 'Three Sacks of Rice'.

Arrange the story in the form of a sequence of pictures.

Decide what you will show in each picture; what words/lines you will write with each picture to explain what happens in it.

You can also add 'speech balloons' for the people in the pictures.